Aquifer Open Study Notes

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2 Thessalonians

2 Thessalonians 1:1–2

Paul uses ancient letter writing customs. Instead of the usual greeting, he blesses them with grace and peace.

2 Thessalonians 1:2

God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ are the co-equal source of grace and peace. The Thessalonians' hope relied on God's grace (2:16). Even during times when Christians were treated badly, they could feel peace from God (3:16).

2 Thessalonians 1:3

- Brothers: Greek adelphoi, a term for family members, both male and female.
- thank God: The apostle Paul starts by expressing thanks for the Thessalonians' faith and love, and how they are enduring (1:4). These are key Christian virtues (see 1 Corinthians 13:13; Colossians 1:4–5; Hebrews 10:21–24; 1 Peter 2:1–22). These virtues were increasing in the church despite the bad treatment they encountered (2 Thessalonians 1:5).

2 Thessalonians 1:3–10

After thanking God for the Thessalonian church, the apostle Paul writes about persecution (1:3–4). This had become worse since his first letter (1 Thessalonians 1:6; 2:14; 3:3–4). God will ease their suffering and judge those who persecute the church (2 Thessalonians 1:5–10).

2 Thessalonians 1:4

Paul praised the Thessalonians' perseverance and faith to other churches. This praise would encourage the Thessalonians to remain strong and loyal despite persecution (1 Thessalonians 2:14; 3:3–4).

2 Thessalonians 1:5

Those whom God calls to enter his kingdom will suffer for it (Acts 14:22; 1 Thessalonians 2:12).

2 Thessalonians 1:7

- rest: This refers to relief from suffering.
- Paul talks about Christ's "coming" several times (2:1; 1 Thessalonians 2:19; 3:13; 4:15; 5:23). Here, he says when the Lord Jesus is revealed, since he is not currently visible in a physical form (compare 1 Peter 1:7–8; 4:13).

2 Thessalonians 1:9

- They will encounter punishment for rejecting the message about Christ (1:8).
- Eternal destruction (see 1 Thessalonians 5:3; 1 Timothy 6:9) is an endless separation from the Lord.
- The phrase separated from the Lord refers to the source of the judgment that is coming (Isaiah 2:10, 19, 21).

2 Thessalonians 1:10

that day: This refers to the day of the Lord (see 2:2 and 1 Thessalonians 5:2–4; see "The Day of the Lord" Theme Note).

2 Thessalonians 1:11

- Will count you worthy of His calling: Paul had reminded the Thessalonians that God called them to act in a way God would consider worthy (1 Thessalonians 2:12; see also Ephesians 4:1; Philippians 1:27; Colossians 1:10).
- Paul prayed that God would give the Thessalonian Christians the power to live and work in a way that would please God.

2 Thessalonians 1:11–12

Paul assures the Thessalonian Christians that God promises justice for both them and those who persecute them (1:5–10). Future salvation means doing hard work now, so Paul prays they will be worthy when Christ returns.

2 Thessalonians 1:12

Those who persecuted the Thessalonians rejected the name of our Lord Jesus (1:8). But Jesus will ultimately be glorified through the lives of Christians. Christians will also share in his honor (2:14; 1 Thessalonians 2:12; see Romans 8:17–18; Colossians 3:4; see Isaiah 66:5)

2 Thessalonians 2:1

When our Lord Jesus Christ returns, God will gather all his followers to meet him (1:7–10; 1 Thessalonians 2:19; 3:13; 4:15–5:2; 5:23). This will happen during the resurrection of the church (1 Thessalonians 4:13–18).

2 Thessalonians 2:1–12

False teachings about the Day of the Lord had upset the Thessalonian church (2:1–2). Paul reminds them that two events will happen before that day: a great rebellion and the revealing of the man of lawlessness (2:3–12). Christ will destroy this man when he returns (2:3, 8). Those deceived by him will also encounter judgment (2:9–12).

2 Thessalonians 2:2

- The Thessalonian Christians had previously asked Paul when the Day of the Lord would come (1 Thessalonians 5:1–11). Now, a false teaching claimed this day had already passed (see 2 Timothy 2:18). This caused the church to doubt their faith and feel scared.
- any spirit or message or letter: The source of this teaching might have been a false prophecy, a sermon they did not understand, or a letter someone falsely claimed to be written by Paul.

2 Thessalonians 2:3

- Two events will happen before the Day of the Lord (2:2).
- Both Jewish and Christian teachings predict a great rebellion against God before the end of time (Matthew 24:11–14; 1 Timothy 4:1).
- the man of lawlessness: He is without law or against law. Sin defines his character.
- the son of destruction: The focus is the lawless man's own destruction, not just on the destruction he causes (2 Thessalonians 2:8).

2 Thessalonians 2:4

- exalt himself: Like other Roman cities, Thessalonica built temples to worship the emperor (king). This religion (cult) was the model for the worship described here.
- he will seat himself in the temple of God: Antiochus Epiphanes polluted the temple in Jerusalem in 167 BC (see Daniel 9:27; 11:31; 12:11). This might have anticipated the event prophesied here (Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14). It could also refer to Emperor Caligula's attempt to place his image in the temple in AD 40.
- Alternatively, the temple might be a temple of the emperor. Here, of God could mean of the god. They will build this temple to honor the man of lawlessness. It is not necessarily the temple in Jerusalem.
- proclaiming himself to be God (Ezekiel 28:2–10): In the first century AD, people often gave divine titles to the emperor.

2 Thessalonians 2:6

what is now restraining him: People have many ideas about who this person is, including:

- God,
- the Holy Spirit,
- the church,
- the good news about Jesus (the gospel),
- Paul,
- the emperor,
- the Roman Empire, or
- the government.

Alternatively, the term may refer to something or someone who comes before the man of lawlessness, an agent of lawlessness active at that time (2:7–8).

In Greek literature, this expression could describe being possessed by a demon (evil angel). This figure would prepare the way for the man of lawlessness when his time comes (2:3, 8).

2 Thessalonians 2:7

- The power of the coming man of lawlessness is already at work in secret, similar to the antichrists in 1 John 2:18 (see 2 Thessalonians 2:3–6).
- the mystery (Greek mustērion): This term is often used for ceremonies in mystery religions (see 2 Thessalonians 2:6).
- at work: This suggests a spiritual intervention, whether divine or evil (1 Thessalonians 2:13; 2 Thessalonians 2:9; Ephesians 2:2).
- the one who now restrains: This might be someone opposing the man of lawlessness, someone possessed by a demon (evil angel), or Satan, the one who possesses (2 Thessalonians 2:9; see study note on 2:6).

2 Thessalonians 2:8

- Paul warns about the destruction of the lawless one (see 2:3). This man This figure pretends to be divine, puts his cult above all other worship (2:4), and gains power from Satan (2:9). However, the Lord Jesus will completely destroy him (Isaiah 11:4).
- majesty: This refers to Christ's appearance, in Greek, epiphaneia ("epiphany") (1 Timothy 6:14; 2 Timothy 1:10; 4:1, 8; Titus 2:13). This is another way to describe Christ's coming or revelation (2 Thessalonians 2:1; 1 Thessalonians 2:19; 3:13; 4:15; 5:23; 2 Thessalonians 1:7). In ancient writings, an epiphany was when a god appeared or showed divine power, inspiring worship.

2 Thessalonians 2:9

Christ will appear in royal and divine power. It is his parousia, meaning "presence" or "arrival" or "coming" (2:1, 8; 1 Thessalonians 2:19; 3:13; 4:15; 5:23). The coming (parousia) of the lawless one will also include a royal entrance.

2 Thessalonians 2:11

As seen in other parts of Scripture (Exodus 9:12; 2 Chronicles 18:22), God sometimes allows people to

follow the sin or delusion they prefer instead of the truth (Romans 1:24, 26, 28; 11:8).

2 Thessalonians 2:12

God will find them guilty because they do not believe the truth (see 1:6–9). They chose to believe the lie of the man of lawlessness instead (see 2:10 and 2:9–10).

2 Thessalonians 2:14

- He called you: God calls his chosen ones to himself through the preaching of the good news about Jesus (1:11; 1 Thessalonians 2:12; 4:7; 5:24).
- Those who suffer because of the Christian faith will ultimately share in the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ (Romans 5:2; 8:17–18; Colossians 1:27; 1 Thessalonians 2:12).

2 Thessalonians 2:15

Since the Thessalonian church began, Paul has cared about the stability of their faith (1 Thessalonians 3:2, 5, 8; 4:1–2). He also cares about their commitment to his teachings (2 Thessalonians 3:6; 1 Corinthians 11:2; 15:3; see Jude 1:3).

2 Thessalonians 2:16

eternal comfort and good hope: These go beyond both death and uncertainty about the near future.

2 Thessalonians 2:17

- Paul's prayer echoes the purpose of Timothy's visit to the church. He came to strengthen and encourage the Thessalonian Christians in their faith (1 Thessalonians 3:2).
- He wanted to encourage and strengthen them because of their fears and doubts (2 Thessalonians 2:1–12; 1 Thessalonians 4:18; 5:11).

2 Thessalonians 3:1

pray for us: The prayer for the gospel to spread quickly reminds us of Psalm 147:15. Paul combines this image with references to the Roman games in which a winner received honor (see 1 Corinthians 9:24–26; Galatians 2:2).

2 Thessalonians 3:1–5

Before discussing the final topic of the letter (3:6–15), Paul asks for prayers (3:1–2). He assures the Thessalonians of God's help during difficult times (3:3–5).

2 Thessalonians 3:2

Paul also suffered for the good news about Jesus (2 Corinthians 6:5; 11:23–26; 1 Thessalonians 2:2). His prayer for rescue echoes Isaiah 25:4.

2 Thessalonians 3:3

The Thessalonians experienced suffering caused by the evil one (or by evil; see 2:9; compare 1:4–6; 1 Thessalonians 1:6; 2:14).

2 Thessalonians 3:5

The prayer for God to direct (literally make straight) their hearts comes from an Old Testament expression (1 Chronicles 29:18; Proverbs 23:19). Christians should love like God and show patience like Christ.

2 Thessalonians 3:6

- Paul gives his command by the authority of the Lord Jesus Christ (1 Thessalonians 4:2).
- Church members should avoid Christians who are lazy (see 2 Thessalonians 3:7, 11–13; 1 Thessalonians 5:14). Staying away from undisciplined people would strongly impact them (Matthew 18:17; Romans 16:17; 1 Corinthians 5:9–13). This would promote shame and repentance (2 Thessalonians 3:14), but it would stop short of removal from the church (3:15).

2 Thessalonians 3:6–15

In his previous letter, Paul addressed the issue of church members who were lazy and refused to work (1 Thessalonians 4:11–12; 5:14). Some ignored his message and example, so he provides more guidance on how to treat these members.

2 Thessalonians 3:7

In the ancient world, people valued teaching by example. Paul set a good example by working to earn his own food (3:8; 1 Thessalonians 2:9).

2 Thessalonians 3:8

without paying for it: Paul taught that workers in the Christian church could receive pay for their labor (3:9; see Matthew 10:10; 1 Corinthians 9:7–14; 1 Timothy 5:17–18). However, he did not use that privilege (1 Thessalonians 2:9; 2 Thessalonians 3:6–10).

2 Thessalonians 3:9

Paul had separated himself from people in the culture who sought fame and money (1 Thessalonians 2:5).

2 Thessalonians 3:10

Work is the right way to earn a living (see Genesis 3:17–19; Psalm 128:2; Proverbs 10:4). Paul says the church is not responsible for feeding Christians who refuse to work.

2 Thessalonians 3:12

- Paul emphasizes the strength of the command by referring to the authority of the Lord Jesus Christ (as in 3:6; 1 Thessalonians 4:1–2).
- begin working quietly: This means to live a quiet life instead of concerning oneself with other people's activities (see 1 Thessalonians 4:11).

2 Thessalonians 3:13

well-doing: Paul encouraged the Thessalonians to help those truly in need, not those who are lazy and dependent (see Galatians 6:9–10; 2 Thessalonians 3:7–8, 10).

2 Thessalonians 3:14

Paul hoped the Christians who disobeyed and were separated from the community would feel ashamed and ask God to forgive them (see study note on 3:6).

2 Thessalonians 3:15

do not regard him as an enemy: In the ancient world, people broke social ties with enemies and took revenge against them. The apostle Paul warns the Thessalonians that discipline against Christians who disobey should not lead to this kind of attack (3:14). Instead, the church should treat them like family members, and act in hope that they will correct their behavior (1 Thessalonians 5:12, 14).

2 Thessalonians 3:16

The final prayer repeats the blessing Jesus spoke in John 14:27 (see also Numbers 6:26). It contrasts with the challenges Christians encountered in Thessalonica (2 Thessalonians 1:4–10; 1 Thessalonians 2:14). Paul was always aware of the presence of the Lord Jesus with his people (Romans 15:33; Philippians 4:9).

2 Thessalonians 3:17

A secretary wrote this letter for Paul (Romans 16:22; 1 Peter 5:12). Now Paul picks up the pen to add a final greeting written by his own hand (see 1 Corinthians 16:21; Galatians 6:11; Colossians 4:18; Philemon 1:19). He does this because he suspects someone is using his name and circulating a letter he did not write (2 Thessalonians 2:2). He emphasizes this step to prove the letter is truly from him.

2 Thessalonians 3:18

Ancient letters often ended with a wish for health or prosperity. However, Paul's blessing is much grander. He asks the Lord Jesus Christ to give grace to the recipients (see 1 Thessalonians 5:28).